

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Life from Death ~ Two Ways
Eastertide 1

April 27th, 2025



"Paesaggio Aereo" Gerardo Dottori, 1936

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Hymn Improvisation

Jesu, Joy Of Man's Desiring, BWV 147, and beyond (Bull after Bach)

Now The Green Blade Rises (Christoph Bull)

Meditation on *Victimae Paschali Laudes*

Vic 1 (Christoph Bull)

Michel Von Loh, *Guitar*, Christoph Bull, *Organ*

Shine On You Crazy Diamond (Gilmour, Waters, Wright)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Emily Kang, Doug Hart, & Rev. Lehman

It only makes sense
[when you think about it]
that we've evolved from some previous form,
its own function defined and confined
by its capacities,
its contexts,
its world.

It only makes sense
[when you think about it]
that being stuck where it was
wasn't enough,
its wings spreading,
feet strengthening,
back shifting to upright.

It only makes sense
[when you think about it]
that we aren't finished either
but only half through becoming
what it is we might become.

But it is hard to think about it
in the midst of life,
boggled as we are by its complexities.

Beginning this morning...
may we find the space, the permission, the time,
to open our minds to an evolutionary extrapolation and
[when we're ready]
imagine ourselves in flight.

*As those confined but not defined
by our physical realities,
we stretch toward an unknown future.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Creator of All Time and Space

TALLIS' CANON

Creator of all time and space,
We read your image on each face.
Great Spirit of the cosmic whole,
You made us body, mind, and soul.

We thank you for the human mind,
In mystic harmony designed,
For word and image, dream and thought,
For lessons learned and answers sought.

O God of planet, moon, and sun,
We wonder, knowing all you've done,
That you befriend the human race,
And fill our lives with love and grace.

For miracles as large as space,
As small as cells, as deep as grace,
We offer you our thanks and praise,
And pledge to serve you all our days.
-lyrics by Ruth C. Duck

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Holy Presence,
we are held by an awesome beauty.
Above, below, surrounding us
is your constant presence of Life.

*It calls to us,
urges us beyond our own
understandings of ourselves
places before us images of its own limitlessness
so that we may see, in its reflection, our own.*

As we fully enter into this time and space,
may we sense the Life we bring to this place,
honor and delight in it,
and know it as that within which we find our
meaning.
*We pray this in the name of the One
who brought us Life.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

"The Arrival: A Fanfare"
Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*

KATHLEEN WISSINGER

***The Lord's Prayer**

Ayur Barduev

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*
John Philip Newell
Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

We live in a world of surprise and beauty,
a world of color and complexity,
a world of challenge and delight,
a world of anxiety and alleluias.

*We are lifted and fed by the wonder in it,
humbled and laid low by its tragic realities.
In the interwoven moments of its blessing and blight,
we make our lives.*

May we, in the spaces between sorrow and delight,
in the moments between harsh reality and beauty,
in the fear that lies in wait between truth and possibility,
learn the art of making light,
that we might shine with peace
and live with hope.

*Together on this journey,
we share what comes
with dignity, grace, and love.*

On this day, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

A Reading from the Hebrew Bible *from Genesis 1*

Ayur Barduev

Listen to these words from the creation story found in the book of Genesis in the Hebrew Bible.

This is the wisdom of the ancestors in faith..

Thanks be to God.

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words for the Silence

To whom it may concern:

There was a moment today –

the first in years –

when I considered calling on you.

For an instant, it occurred to me

that you might not be

as I had decided you were.

I suddenly wondered if, instead,

you might be the one

whom I most need.

And my heart flash-flooded with hope.

If my suspicions are correct,

maybe we can start to talk again

as we once did. [vinceamlin]

Prayers of Our Hearts

Gracious One,

we are aware that no road takes us to a sure place.

If we have been there before,

what we remember of it

may have changed, people moved away,

buildings altered.

What we remember

holds us in the moment of time

we last experienced the reality of the place.

But even should the walls remain in place,

the trees around be strong and yet as broad,

the people unchanged from when we last arrived –

the places of our hearts know new terrain

and we, who carry it within us,

will see with different eyes.

On this day, may we be open to what our eyes tell us of our lives

not just of places well-known and loved,

but of new land, new discoveries, new places of the heart.

This we pray,
as those who walk a common road.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Fantasy on Immortal, Invisible"
Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*

DOUGLAS FLOYD SMITH

Sermon

Life after Death: Two Ways

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Welcome to this banqueting table.
This is a table of hospitality, of sharing, and of celebration.
We break bread and pour the fruit of the vine
because these are the gifts that strengthen our journey together.

Remembering our Common Humanity...
We remember and honor the justice imperative
that is the biblical heritage:
justice is not belief but action,
not silence but voice,
not tolerance but compassion.

The call to follow justice is easy to issue,
but the resolve to follow justice is difficult to muster.
Together, let us be a community
that not only issues the word but follows the dictate.

*May our community be one that holds
the strength of compassion and the resolve to act.
May we be a people who unites
our words with our deeds.
For the dignity of life and the hope of humanity,
may it be so.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Communion Music

"Meditation With Cat and Crane"
Michel von Loh, *Guitar*

MICHEL VON LOH

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"A Little Light"

BRANDI CARLISLE AND ELTON JOHN

David Harris, Michel von Loh, *Guitar*, David Kang, *Piano*, William Kang, *Bass*,
Rev. Michael Lehman, *Percussion*, and Christoph Bull, *Organ*

"That's why we're gonna get up, point our chin towards the sun, say a little prayer and count our blessings one by one. Don't hide yourself away. Don't grow hard from what you've heard. You gotta break your heart wide open, let a little light into the world."

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Ayur Barduev

Holy One, as we leave this place...
May the story of this week
inspire us in ways that bring us a hope-filled clarity
about who we are, what we can do,
what it is our lives might be about.

*And as we walk this dusty path,
may we see only
the love and passion of those who journey with us -
and be inspired.*

[adapt/gvosper]

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Life continues to be filled with deep mysteries.
Although we entered this place
to come to understand them more fully,
it is beyond these walls,
in the common things of the everyday,
that we most regularly meet them.
Starlight, wind, rain falling into puddles,
music in the silence of a smile.

*On this day,
we have opened ourselves to the contemplation of mystery
but let us never confine it to this space.
Remind us that we will find it everywhere!*

As those who walk in mystery,
we say...

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Danza del Altiplano (sobre un tema folklórico)"
Michael von Loh, *Guitar*

LEO BROUWER

***Hymn for the Journey**

The Journey of Faith

BEACH SPRING

To a journey God has called us,
To a life of love and hope;
In the light and in the shadow,
God is with us as we go.
Faith that grows with each new challenge,
Trust that leads through paths unknown,
We, as pilgrims, walk together
In the journey to our home.

For the strength of faithful witness
Lived through days of joy and tears;
And the gift of grace sufficient
For the ever-flowing years;
For the richness of Your mercy
To Thee, Lord, we give our praise.
May our lives reflect Your glory
'Till the close of all our days.

Go we now to be God's people,
Go we now our faith to live.
Help us learn from one another
Faith to keep, a faith to give.
Go we now on life's great journey,
Go we now, but not alone.
With God's people, by God's Spirit,
Faith leads forward, faith leads on.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*
Vic 1 - Reprise (Christoph Bull)

Inside The Music

"The choir has a much-deserved break this week and we are led by the Cathedral Ringers and guitarist Michel von Loh. We have a great gift in the presence of our Cathedral Ringers. I grew up playing hand bells, and there are few joys like playing and hearing a hand bell choir. Sadly, there are fewer and fewer of them in the world each year. Like compelling organ music, we have the joy of the presence of profound beauty that isn't that common to find in its form. The music this week all focuses on the revelations that exist in front of us that we can't always see, but that surround us in promise. The hymn "Immortal Invisible" makes this very statement. Even though we won't hear the words from the hand

bells, we can hear in the music God's ubiquitous and unceasing presence. Pink Floyd's "Shine On You Crazy Diamond" was recorded in 1975 as a tribute to a former band member. Again, we won't hear the words in the organ/guitar arrangement that Michel and Christoph will be playing, but the meaning will shine through. The band wanted to let their former creative partner know how much they love and appreciate him, even though he couldn't be with them any more. He had experienced profound struggles in his life, but was still, as we can hear in the vast wonderment of this tribute song, full of a spirit of promise. Brandi Carlisle and Elton John released a collaborative album a few weeks ago. I listened to it, being a fan of both of them, and was struck by how well "A Little Light" would feel the week after Easter. It is an anthem for this moment in time, written for all of us by two people who have been in the social justice trenches. Their individual brands of hopefulness mingle to create a song of spiritual power and presence. The music rolls along in the light rock ballad style that both of them helped to define. It is emblematic of all that they have accomplished in their creative careers, and a crisp reminder that we all have plenty of blessings to count and plenty of light left to shine into this world." - Dr. David Harris